On the Possibility of an Inherited Error in the Formulation of Fundamental Questions

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Abstract

Why does anything exist at all? Almost every answer to a question about the origin of the world invites a further question: where did the thing offered as an explanation itself come from? This essay examines the possibility that the difficulty lies not only in the limits of available knowledge but also in an inherited way of framing the question. Certain explanatory categories may have become established through their practical usefulness and gradually come to be treated as universal features of reality. The central concern is the move from explaining the origins of particular objects to demanding an explanation for the origin of existence as such. The discussion places this idea in dialogue with philosophical work on presuppositions, the limits of cognition, and the history of scientific paradigms. It also considers objections that prevent the conjecture from being regarded as a demonstrated theory. The aim is to articulate the problem and outline a possible line of inquiry, not to claim that human thought has already been shown to be fundamentally mistaken.

Keywords: epistemology, metaphysics, causation, infinite regress, presuppositions, conceptual error, origin of the universe, philosophy of language.

1. The Question That Reproduces Itself

Human beings can explain the origins of many things. Earth formed from material in the protoplanetary disk; chemical elements have histories involving particular physical processes; individual events can be explained by reference to earlier conditions. Yet explanations that appeal to something prior share a distinctive feature: they do not end the possibility of asking another question.

If an event occurred because of certain conditions, we can ask where those conditions came from. If those conditions are explained by an earlier state, the question arises again. Pushed to its limit, this chain leads to the question, “Where did everything come from?” and, more pointedly, “How could there have been a first thing if that, too, must have come from something else?”

The problem of infinite causal regress and the question of a first ground have long been discussed in philosophy, especially in debates over cosmological arguments [1]. But there is another way to approach the difficulty. What if it is not merely that we have yet to find the right member of the chain? What if the structure of the question already assumes that such a member must exist? Searching for an answer and examining the conditions under which a question makes sense would then be two distinct philosophical tasks.

This essay is concerned with the second task. Its central conjecture is that certain ways of asking about reality may have become historically entrenched—so thoroughly that they are experienced not as adopted methods of explanation, but as intrinsic features of existence itself.

2. From Not Knowing to Asking the Wrong Kind of Question

Three claims must be distinguished. First, we do not possess a final answer to the question of the origin of everything. Second, we may not yet possess a method capable of yielding such an answer. Third, the question itself may contain a presupposition that does not apply to its subject matter.

The first claim proves neither the second nor the third. The absence of an answer does not automatically make a question meaningless. Moreover, “Why is there something rather than nothing?”, “What was the earliest event?”, and “What grounds the existence of the world?” are not equivalent questions. The first concerns existence, the second a temporal sequence, and the third a possible ground that need not be an earlier event at all.

Care is therefore essential. This essay does not claim that causation is unreal or that science misdescribes the universe. It raises the possibility that an explanatory pattern that works well for particular phenomena is sometimes transferred without justification to reality as a whole. To establish such a transfer, we must identify a specific presupposition. It is not enough to observe that the question is exceedingly difficult.

3. The Hypothesis of Inherited Conceptual Error

An inherited conceptual error, as the term is used here, is a potentially mistaken or unjustifiably universalized presupposition that is repeatedly transmitted through language, upbringing, education, and practices of inquiry, until its status as a presupposition becomes difficult to recognize.

“Inherited” does not mean that a single first human once committed a mistake that every descendant now repeats genetically. The human species did not emerge through a single individual act, and the claim that a specific philosophical disposition became genetically fixed would require independent biological evidence. The primary concern here is cultural inheritance: later generations receive not only established answers but also habitual ways of constructing questions.

Consider a hypothetical sequence. People adopt an explanatory pattern that is useful in everyday experience. The pattern is passed on, embedded in language and education, and eventually treated as an implicit rule: this is how existence *must* be thought about. The difficulty arises when we move from “this model explains events accessible to us” to “this model must explain every possible reality without exception.”

The possibility of such a move does not, by itself, prove that a global error has occurred. It does, however, describe a mechanism that can be examined historically and logically.

4. What Philosophy Already Knows About the Foundations of Questions

The proposed problem has important precedents. Immanuel Kant investigated the limits of the categories of understanding and the antinomies that arise when reason considers the world

as a totality. The question of whether the world has a beginning in time, in particular, illustrates the importance of distinguishing the conditions of experience from attempts to reason beyond them [2].

R. G. Collingwood discussed “absolute presuppositions” that make particular questions possible and shape the character of an inquiry [3]. Thomas Kuhn argued that scientific paradigms influence which problems are regarded as meaningful and which methods are accepted [4]. Colin McGinn introduced the phrase *interrogative closure* to describe the possibility of questions that we cannot adequately formulate because we lack the requisite concepts [5].

The differences among these positions matter. Kant did not simply declare every category to be an historically inherited error; Collingwood did not treat each absolute presupposition as a false belief; Kuhn did not show that scientific paradigms are entirely detached from the world; and McGinn's discussion primarily concerns possible limits of cognitive capacity. The conjecture developed here emphasizes a different possibility: a way of thinking may be available to human beings and successful in practice, while its historical entrenchment makes the limits of its applicability harder to notice.

We are not, therefore, claiming the discovery of a new law of thought. The contribution proposed here is a possible connection between already recognized problems: the historical character of presuppositions, the cultural transmission of concepts, and the less visible limits of fundamental questioning.

5. The Central Case: Where Did “Everything” Come From?

The question “Where did this object come from?” can generally be answered by referring to earlier objects, conditions, or processes. But when we ask “Where did *everything that exists* come from?”, any answer of the form “from something else” already assumes that something exists. An explanatory model developed for parts of reality may therefore fail to fit the task of accounting for reality as a whole.

This observation does not dissolve the metaphysical problem. Some philosophers describe a first ground not as the first event in time but as necessary existence, a sustaining cause, or a ground of dependence [1]. An infinite regress is another possibility, and philosophers disagree about whether every such regress is vicious. It would therefore be unjustified to dismiss the entire philosophical tradition as captive to one mistaken question.

A more precise statement of the present thesis is conditional: if we tacitly assume that everything must have an explanation that is *temporally prior*, then a question about the origin of everything may illegitimately extend temporal causation beyond the domain in which its applicability has been established.

It may be more productive to ask not “What came before everything?” but “What kind of explanation, if any, is appropriate when the subject is everything that exists?” This shift does

not promise a final answer. It allows us to investigate the structure of the difficulty rather than endlessly repeating the question in its familiar form.

6. Why Practical Success Does Not Guarantee Universality

An obvious objection arises: if human concepts were mistaken, how could science make such remarkably accurate predictions? This objection must be taken seriously. Scientific knowledge is supported by observations, experiments, and successful technological applications. These achievements cannot be dismissed merely by invoking the idea of a supposed “human error.”

Nevertheless, a theory's success under particular conditions does not mean that its familiar concepts automatically apply to every level or scale of reality. A model may be useful and accurate while remaining limited to a particular domain. The history of scientific revolutions shows that established concepts can be revised without rendering every earlier result useless [4].

Only a modest conclusion follows: it is rational to investigate the boundaries of our concepts even when they are useful. The stronger claim—that all scientific knowledge is mistaken—does not follow. The inherited-conceptual-error hypothesis would become substantive only if it could identify a particular hidden extension and explain why that extension is unwarranted.

7. The Strongest Objection: Can We Detect an Error Using Our Own Logic?

Suppose all human logic were wrong. The argument used to establish that claim would itself employ the very methods being called into question. A global version of the hypothesis threatens to undermine its own grounds.

A more coherent version is therefore limited: some familiar categories may be used beyond the bounds of their justification, without this making all critical thought unreliable. We can search for contradictions, compare alternative descriptions, clarify the meanings of terms, and test the consequences of our claims. These activities are themselves forms of human thinking, yet they can reveal local failures within it.

There is also a deeper criticism. Donald Davidson questioned the very notion of radically incommensurable conceptual schemes [6]. If we posit a wholly different and fundamentally untranslatable way of describing reality, we must ask why it should count as another *description of the same reality* at all. This objection makes it difficult to claim, too casually, that a completely inaccessible “correct logic” must exist.

The hypothesis should therefore not require faith in some unknown ideal system of thought. Its subject is the criticism of specific presuppositions within the forms of inquiry available to us.

8. A Program for Further Inquiry

To move from a philosophical intuition to a distinctive argument, four steps are necessary.

First, isolate a particular presupposition. In the present case, that might be the belief that every explanation of an origin must appeal to something that existed earlier.

Second, establish that the presupposition is actually present in the question under examination. It must not simply be attributed to all human beings or all philosophers. Different cosmological arguments already employ different notions of cause, ground, and dependence [1].

Third, show that the presupposition is unjustified in a particular domain. This requires constructing a comprehensible alternative formulation that does not simply repeat the assumption under scrutiny.

Fourth, determine what the investigation gains. Does a false contradiction disappear? Do different kinds of explanation become easier to distinguish? Does a new route to critical testing emerge? This undertaking resembles contemporary *conceptual engineering*, which investigates how concepts themselves can be assessed and improved [7].

Even a successful result would not establish that humanity committed one ancient, universal error. It would demonstrate something narrower but philosophically significant: a particular difficulty may depend in part on a familiar, historically inherited, and insufficiently justified form of questioning.

9. Conclusion

Some of humanity's most persistent questions may remain with us not only because we know too little about the world, but because our inherited ways of asking already shape which answers we are prepared to accept. The question “Where did everything come from?” is especially revealing. Explaining something in terms of an earlier existent may work for particular objects while not necessarily working for existence as a whole.

Yet the possibility of this kind of error is not proof that it has occurred. There is insufficient reason to believe that all people have inherited one false system of thought, that biological evolution fixed such an error, or that a fundamental explanation of existence is impossible in principle.

The more carefully defined philosophical problem is this: Can historically inherited ways of formulating questions prevent us from recognizing the limits of our own explanatory framework—and how might we discover this without claiming a vantage point outside human thought?

Perhaps progress begins not by searching for yet another “first thing,” but by examining why we expect there to be such a thing in the first place.

References and Further Reading

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[7] “Conceptual Engineering,” in “Conceptions of Analysis in Analytic Philosophy,” section 10. *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/analysis/s6.html

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